New York State Data Brief For The National Youth In Transition Database (NYTD)
Cohort 4 Report

Background

What is NYTD?

The National Youth in Transition Database (NYTD) is a nationwide data collection system overseen by the U.S. Department of Health and Human Services Administration for Children and Families (ACF) that gathers information on youth aging out of foster care and their experiences across six life domains: educational attainment, financial self-sufficiency, access to health insurance and vital documents, positive connections with adults, experience with homelessness and other situations that could place youth at risk.

Who participates?

NYTD participation begins with a baseline survey administered to youth in foster care within 45 days of their 17th birthday. Youth who complete a baseline survey are then re-surveyed at age 19 and again at age 21, regardless of their foster care status at follow-up. In NYS, youth have the option of remaining in foster care up to age 21 but can choose to exit at any point past age 18. Youth can decline to participate in the survey at any time or may be unable to locate for a follow-up survey for a variety of reasons.

What can we learn from NYTD data?

NYTD data provides insight into how older youth fare as they enter early adulthood and transition out of the foster care system. While states have the flexibility to add survey items, states must use questions set forth by ACF for each of the core domains listed above. Uniform data collection makes it possible to compare youth outcomes across states and to establish national trends.

As shown in the first figure, a new cohort of 17-year-old youth is selected every three years and then followed over a four-year period. By collecting information across successive cohorts of youth at multiple ages, NYTD data also sheds light on how changes in social policies and/or environmental circumstances may differentially impact groups of youth coming of age at different points of time.

Cohort 4 Outcomes

This data brief summarizes the findings for NYS NYTD Cohort 4 and compares their early adulthood experiences to those of NYTD Cohort 3. Both cohort's transitions into young adulthood coincided with the Covid 19 pandemic. For Cohort 3 youth, the pandemic arrived as they entered their twenties, while for Cohort 4 the world was entering lockdown as they approached legal adulthood. We first present Cohort 4 data and discuss any notable differences between the two cohorts at the end of the report.

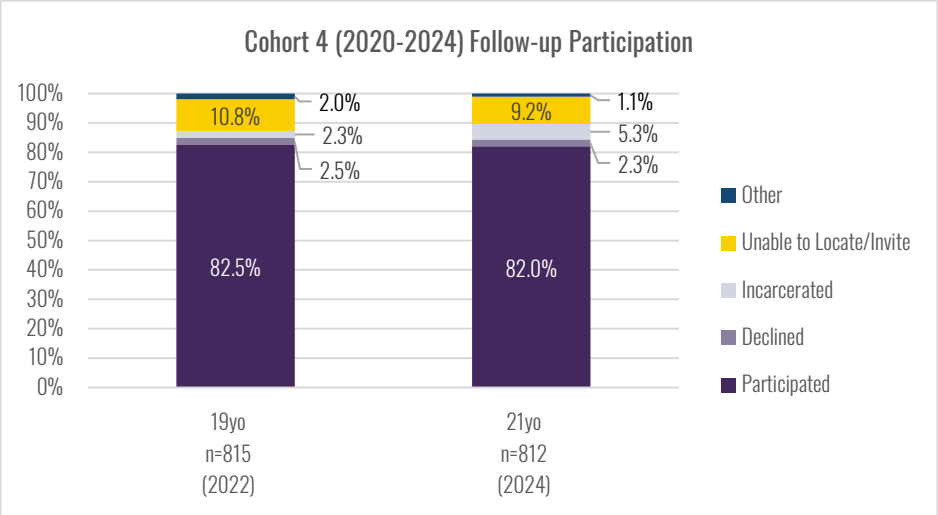
Reporting Population	FFY17	FFY18	FFY19	FFY20 COVID	FFY21	FFY22	FFY23	FFY24
Baseline 17	Cohort 3 (wave 1)			Cohort 4 (wave1)				
Follow-up 19			Cohort 3 (wave 2)			Cohort 4 (wave 2)		
Follow-up 21					Cohort 3 (wave 3)			Cohort 4 (wave3)

Participant Demographics

815 youth participated in the Cohort 4 baseline survey at age 17. Slightly more than half identified as female and 48% as male. The federal questionnaire does not collect gender identity categories outside of the male/female binary. Participants are permitted to select multiple racial/ethnic designations. The most frequently endorsed categories were Black (56.9%), White (46.0%) and Hispanic (27.9%). Gender, ethnicity, and racial distributions were relatively stable across the three waves and were similar to what is observed in the foster care population.

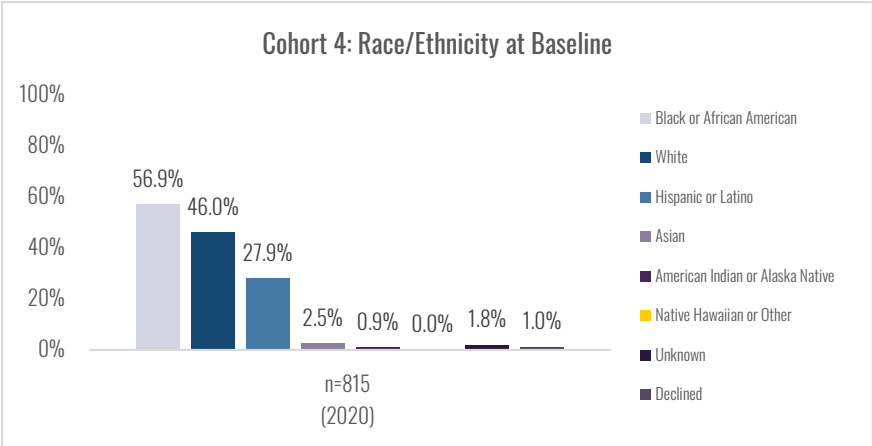
Participation in both follow-up surveys was high. In wave 2, 672 (82.5%) of youth included in the baseline sample completed the age 19 survey. Of the 815 youth expected to be surveyed at age 21 in wave 3, 666 (82.0%) participated.

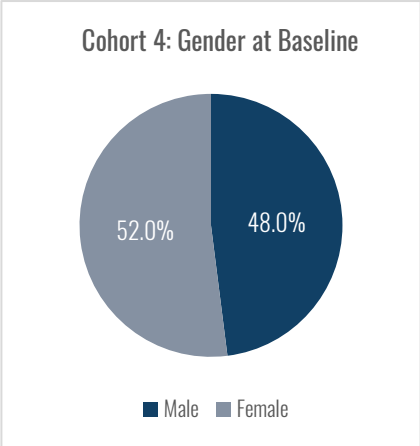
Participation



*Other includes youth who were unable to participate due to being incapacitated, a runaway, parent declined, or deceased.

Gender, Ethnicity, and Racial Distributions



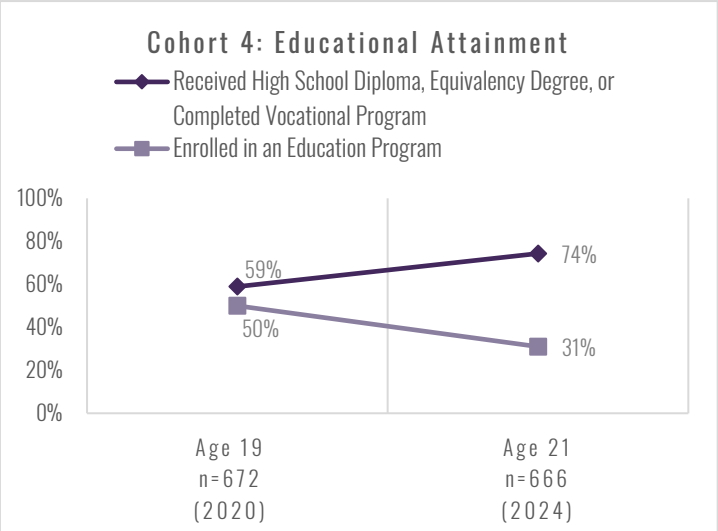


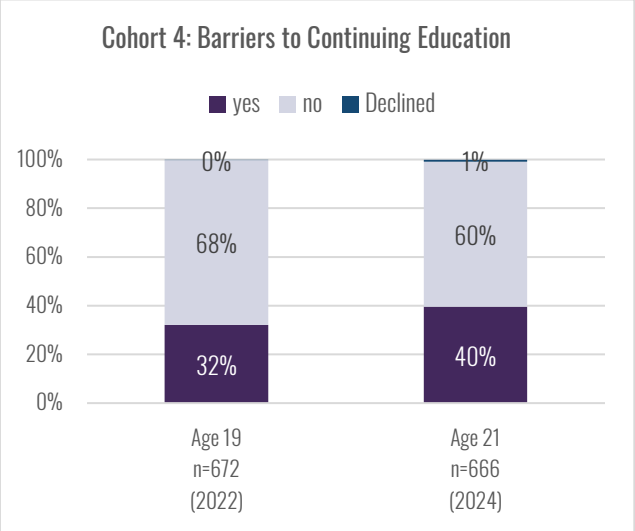
Educational Attainment

Achieving a high school diploma or equivalent can be considered a minimal requirement for self-sufficiency and can assist in establishing a solid educational foundation that will prepare youth for future educational pursuits and career development.

At age 19, 59% of youth indicated they had received their high school diploma, equivalency degree, or completed a vocational program, and 50% stated they were enrolled in an educational program. By age 21, more youth had obtained their high school diploma, equivalency degree, or completed a vocational program (74%) and the percentage of youth enrolled in an education program had dropped to 31%. The modest percentage of youth enrolled in an educational program at age 21 suggests that many youth are not pursuing post-high school educational opportunities. Indeed, 40% of youth at age 21 indicated barriers preventing pursuit of continued education, with the most highly cited reason being unable to pay for school (49%).

Educational Attainment





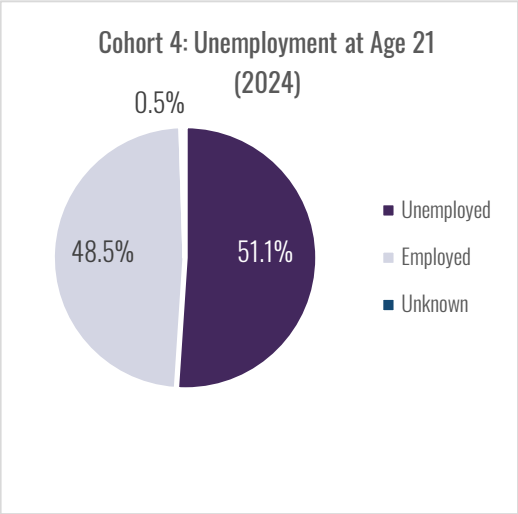
Reasons for Barriers to Continued Education

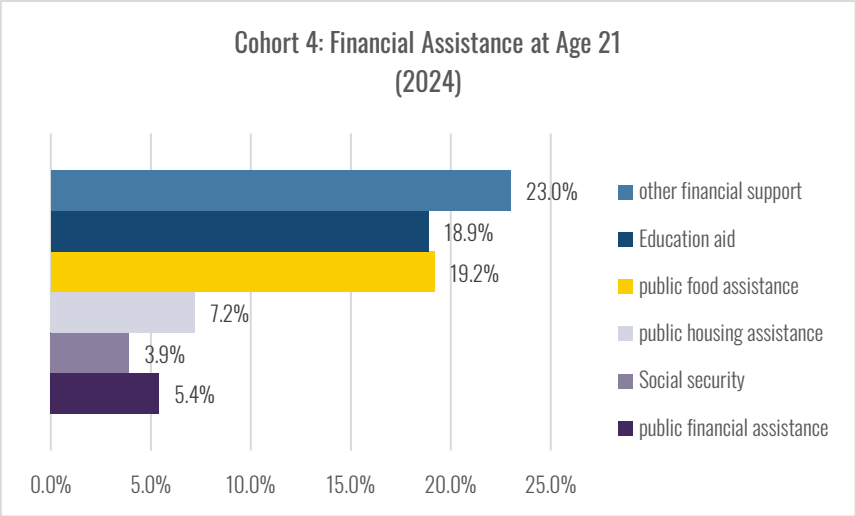
	Cohort 4 (FFY2024)	
	#	%
Total	**265**	**100%**
Unable to pay for school	130	49%
Need to work full time	38	14%
Childcare responsibilities	30	11%
No transportation	13	5%
Discouraged by significant other	0	0%
Have academic difficulties	15	6%
Other	36	14%
Don't know	1	<1%
Declined	2	<1%

Youth's Financial Situation

Employment is an important metric for youth transitioning into adulthood and achieving self-sufficiency.

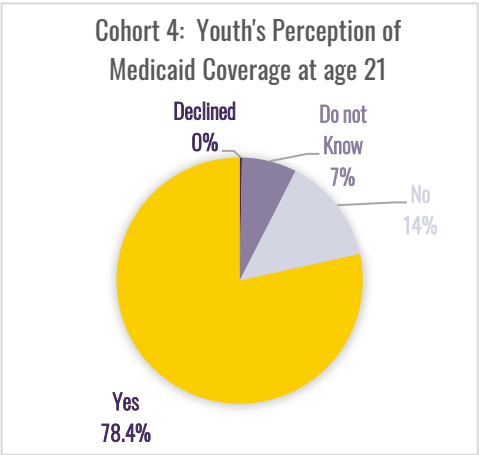
At age 21, about half of cohort 4 youth had either part-time or full-time employment. Surveyed youth at age 21 indicated other financial support (includes payments from a spouse or family member, child support that the youth receives or funds from a legal settlement), education aid, and public food assistance as the three most common categories of financial assistance.





Access To Health Insurance And Important Documents

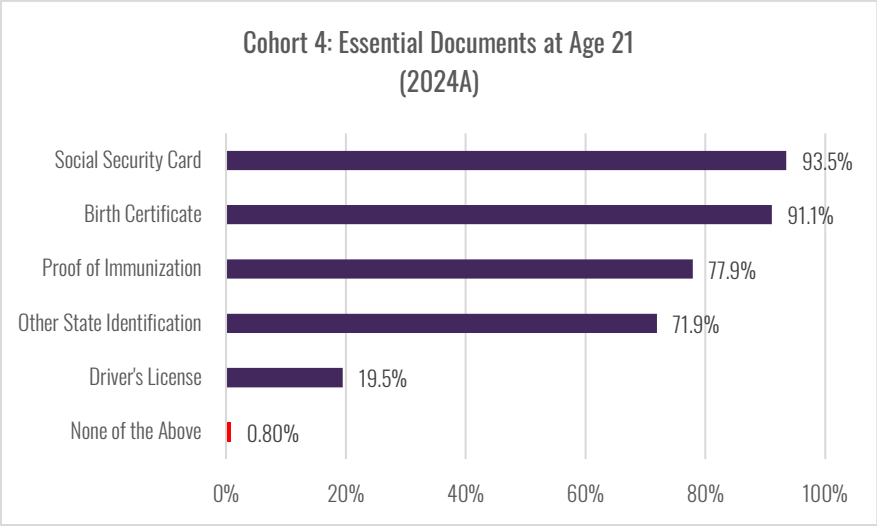
All youth in foster care are categorically eligible for Medicaid, and all youth who exited foster care at or after 18 are eligible for Medicaid until they are 26. However, 14% indicated they did not have Medicaid at 21, and 7% indicated that they did not know if they had Medicaid. Youth discharged from foster care should be eligible for Medicaid. However, 18% of youth 18 or older who participated in the survey indicated that they either did not have or did not know if they had Medicaid. This suggests that there is a lack of clarity for youth leaving care regarding their Medicaid eligibility.



Cohort 4: Youth at age 21 indicating having Medicaid by age at discharge

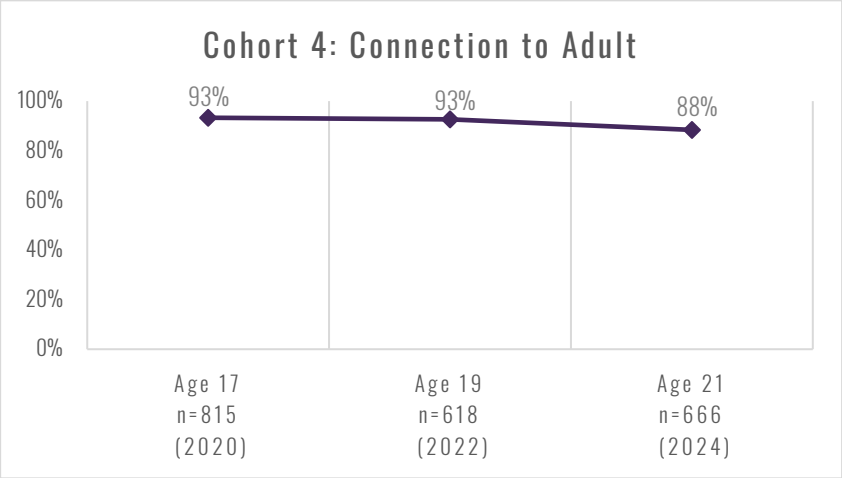
Discharge age	No		Yes		Declined		Do not know		Total	
	#	%	#	%	#	%	#	%	#	%
Total	**93**	**14%**	**522**	**78%**	**3**	**0%**	**48**	**7%**	**666**	**100%**
17	42	27%	107	69%	0	0%	5	3%	154	100%
18+	51	10%	415	81%	3	1%	43	8%	512	100%

A high percentage of youth in Cohort 4 indicated being in possession of essential documents such as their Social Security Card, Birth Certificate, and Proof of Immunization. Less than one percent of youth indicated that they did not have any essential documents in their possession.



Do Our Youth Have Adult Support?

Establishing a positive, consistent, and lasting relationship with at least one adult is a critical component in ensuring youth make a successful transition from foster care to adulthood. The NYTD survey asks whether the youth know at least one adult who they can go to for advice or guidance when there is a decision to make or a problem to solve, or for companionship when celebrating personal achievements. The adult must be easily accessible to the youth, either by telephone or in person, and the definition excludes spouses, partners, boyfriends/girlfriends and current caseworkers. Connection to an adult was high across all waves, but declined by age 21.

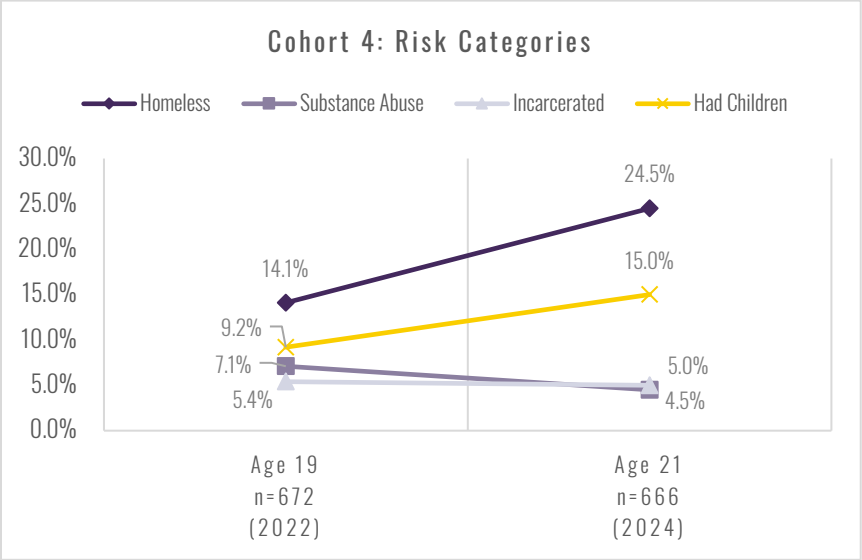


Do Our Youth Evidence Any Risks?

The NYTD survey collects information on four key outcomes as identified by ACF (experiencing homelessness, substance use, incarceration and early transitions to parenthood in the last two years) that have been associated with hindering successful transitions to adulthood.

Homelessness and having a child increased between age 19 and 21, while experience with substance abuse and incarceration showed a slight decrease.

At age 21, the risk category with the highest percentage of respondents was homelessness in the last 2 years (25%), followed by having children at 15%. Five percent of respondents experienced substance abuse and 5% experienced incarceration in the last 2 years.



Effects of remaining in foster care on risk factors: Young adults in NYS are provided the option to remain in extended foster care until they are 21 years old. Youth who opt out of extended foster care and exit early are more at risk for the four key outcomes associated with hindering successful transitions to adulthood. Experiencing homelessness in the last two years is three times higher for youth who exited care at 18 or younger compared to youth who remained in care until 21. Receiving a substance abuse referral, experiencing incarceration, and having a child in the last two years are also higher for youth who did not remain in extended foster care compared to those who did.

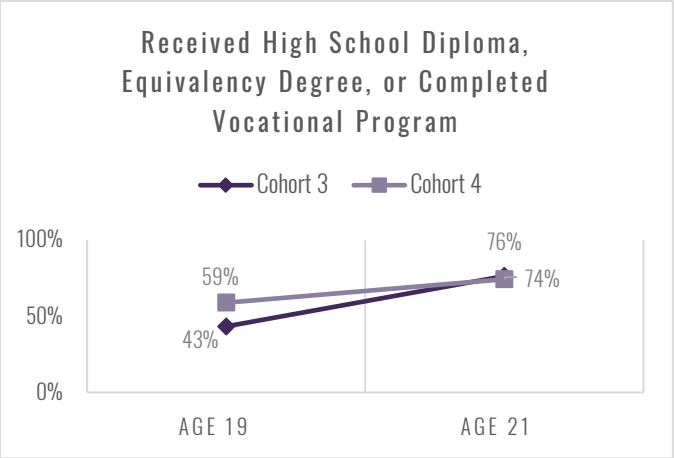
Risk Factors by Age at Discharge for Cohort 4 21-year-olds

Risk Factor	Total (n=666)		Age at Discharge: 18 or younger (n=305)		19-20 (n=121)		21 (n=240)	
	#	%	#	%	#	%	#	%
Homelessness	163	25%	109	36%	25	21%	29	12%
Substance Abuse	30	5%	18	6%	4	3%	8	3%
Incarcerated	33	5%	22	7%	2	2%	9	4%
Had Children	100	15%	59	19%	18	15%	23	10%

Cohort 3 vs Cohort 4 Comparisons

While Cohort 4 was entering legal adulthood as the Covid-19 lockdown came into effect in 2020, Cohort 3 was entering their twenties during this time. We explored if there were any differences between the two cohorts for the various NYTD survey metrics.

- **NYTD Survey Participation**
  - The percentage of youth who participated in the NYTD follow-up surveys at both age 19 and 21 in Cohort 4 was higher than compared to Cohort 3 (75% vs 83% at age 19; 65% vs 82% at age 21).
- **Educational Attainment**
  - A higher percentage of Cohort 4 youth indicated having a high school diploma, equivalency degree, or completed a vocational program at age 19 (59%) compared to Cohort 3 (43%). By age 21, the percentage of youth who had obtained either a high school diploma or a vocational certificate/license was roughly equal.

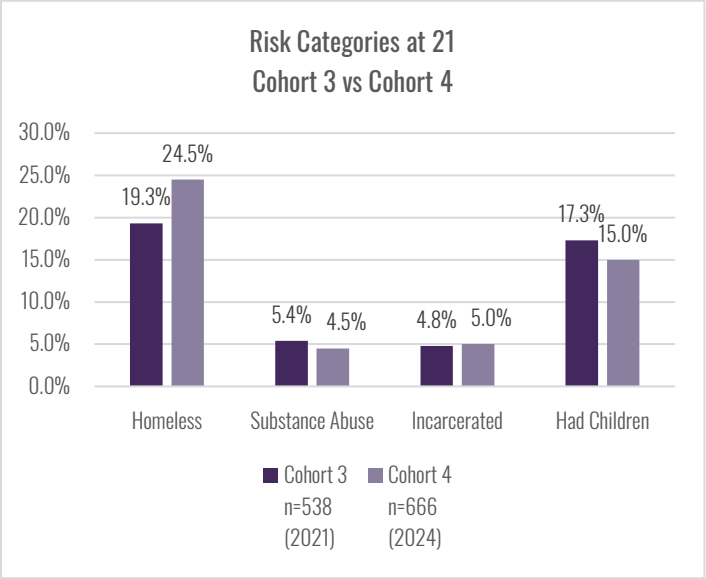


  - A similar percentage of Cohort 4 and Cohort 3 youth indicated barriers to continuing education at age 21. However, a substantially higher percentage of youth in Cohort 4 indicated being unable to pay for school as their main barrier to continued education.

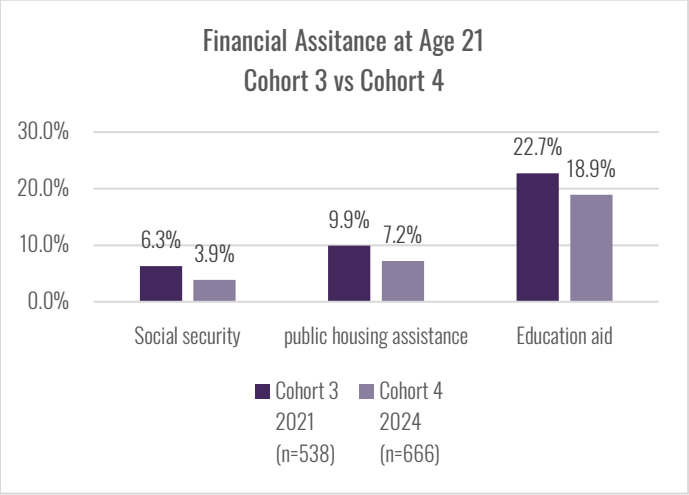
Reasons for Barriers to Continued Education

	Cohort 3 (FFY2021)		Cohort 4 (FFY2024)	
	#	%	#	%
Total	**205**	**100%**	**265**	**100%**
Unable to pay for school	67	33%	130	49%
Need to work full time	38	19%	38	14%
Child care responsibilities	19	9%	30	11%
No transportation	7	3%	13	5%
Discouraged by significant other	0	0%	0	0%
Have academic difficulties	17	8%	15	6%
Other	53	26%	36	14%
Don't know	3	1%	1	<1%
Declined	1	0%	2	<1%

- **Health Insurance and Important Documents**
    - Compared to Cohort 3, a higher percentage of Cohort 4 youth indicated being in possession of essential documents such as Social Security Card, Birth Certificate, and Proof of Immunization. However, a lower percentage of Cohort 4 youth (20%) were in possession of Driver's license compared to Cohort 3 (30%).
- **Risks**
    - At age 21, Cohort 4 youth were more likely than Cohort 3 youth to indicate they had experienced homelessness in the past two years.



- **Financial Assistance**
    - A lower percentage of Cohort 4 youth indicated receiving Social Security, Public Housing Assistance, and Education Aid compared to Cohort 3 youth at age 21. This may have contributed to a higher percentage of Cohort 4 youth indicating financial reasons for not being able to pursue continued education, and a higher percentage of Cohort 4 youth experiencing homelessness.



Concluding Statements

While some outcomes show that NYS youth leaving care after age 17 are experiencing areas of success, there is much work to be done to ensure that youth have a full range of support and opportunities. An increase in financial difficulties to pursue higher education, lack of awareness regarding Medicaid eligibility, and an increase in homelessness for older youth leaving care for our most recent cohort points to a need for support for these outcome areas.